38. Fertile soils, therefore, extend over only about ten percent of the surface of South America. The most important of these are brunizems, deep, dark- coloured prairie soils, developed from wind-deposited loess.
39. In the Andes, slopes are often steep, and lithosols (shallow soils consisting of imperfectly weathered rock fragments) abound, accounting for another ten percent of the continent's surface. In the inter-Andean valleys and on some of the foothills, nevertheless, eutrophic soils (deposited by lakes, and containing much nutrient matter, but often shallow and subject to seasonal oxygen deficiency) can be found.
40. The agricultural development of South America closely reflects the distribution of soils according to their fertility. It is mostly confined to the eastern mid-latitude plains, in which is concentrated the production of cereal grains and cattle grazing; to the subtropical and temperate parts of the Andes, from Colombia to Chile, where grazing takes place and a variety of crops are cultivated; and to eastern and southeastern Brazil, where coffee, cacao, soybeans, and sugarcane are grown, while the interior plateaus are devoted to cattle grazing.
41. In Colombia, the Andes-which trend generally to the north and south-form three distinct ranges: the Cordilleras Oriental, Central and Occidental. The valley of the Magdalena River, between the Oriental and the Central ranges, and the valley of the Cauca iver, between the Central and the Occidental ranges, are huge rift valleys formed by faulting rather than by erosion. An aerial view of the Andes in Colombia shows, within relatively short distances, a succession of hot lowlands interspersed with high ranges with snowcapped peaks.
42. The Andes Mountains extend over seven countries: Argentina, Bolivia, Chile, Colombia, Ecuador, Peru, and Venezuela, known as Andean States. The Andes mountain range is the highest mountain range outside of Asia.
43. Farther to the south-along the border between Chile and Argentina-the Andes form a single but lofty chain with many of the system's highest peaks, including Mount Aconcagua; south of Aconcagua, elevations gradually diminish. In southern Chile part